

The current brands available on the market are Philips Hue, probably the most well-known option around, Philips Lux, and other alternatives by Syska, GE and Belkin (some of these products need to be ordered from outside India). However, the cost of some of these alternatives might burn a hole in your pocket, so you might want to go easy on them. If you intend to extend your entire lighting system, there are intelligent lighting solutions that can be controlled without the hub or directly through your smartphone without a switch. This would help eliminate needless additions to automation if you wish to keep it simple. And in case you're worried about security,



Belkin Smart Switch

smart cameras, such as Nest's Cam Outdoor or LG's IP camera, and smart camera installations coupled with sensors, can be used to create a comprehensive home security system that raises intruder alarms and monitors and records video footage when necessary.

One common pattern in all smart devices is that their functionality is enhanced when they are paired with sensors. Whether you use motion and occupancy sensors to detect empty rooms or movement in rooms to regulate your lighting system, or using contact sensors on doors and windows to monitor their opening and closing and consequently triggering intruder alarms, sensors can help reduce mechanical input even through the app, thus increasing the extent to which you can automate your home.

While the field of home automation has remained limited to small and isolated products up till now, the new ecosystem of more integrated systems, that use feedback from other devices and allow users to program customised needs, is attracting more attention and users. And even though the market is still fragmented and protocols are haywire, it is expected to consolidate and provide users with better home automation systems than ever. And before you know it, a home automation revolution will become the next technology overhaul after the smartphone revolution. **d**